

THE WISDOM OF SOLOMON

Freemasonry and mysticism

Modern Freemasonry was born in England at the end of the 17th century. Its most obvious starting points were medieval Masons, also called Freemasons. They were “free” in two senses of the word—the Masons of the Middle Ages were free men and they were carvers of a form of limestone known as freestone.

Expert knowledge

Masons were the master craftsmen, educated and rigorously trained, responsible for building the great cathedrals and castles of the medieval world. As such, they accumulated a vast store of technical and theoretical knowledge, especially about geometry, which they jealously guarded in tightly knit guilds or craft associations.

Increasingly, Freemasons’ knowledge was spiced with mystical learning: Gnosticism, Hermeticism, Kabbalism (see pp.134–139), alchemy (turning base metals into gold), and even necromancy (the conjuring of demons). Secret rituals expressed their love of the occult.

Elaborate rituals

How and why in the later 17th century these original “operative” Freemasons began admitting those who had never been Masons—“accepted” or “speculative” Masons—remains unclear. However, the impact of this fresh generation of Freemasons was dramatic and lasting. These new members significantly raised the social standing of the

ALESSANDRO DI CAGLIOSTRO (1743–1795)

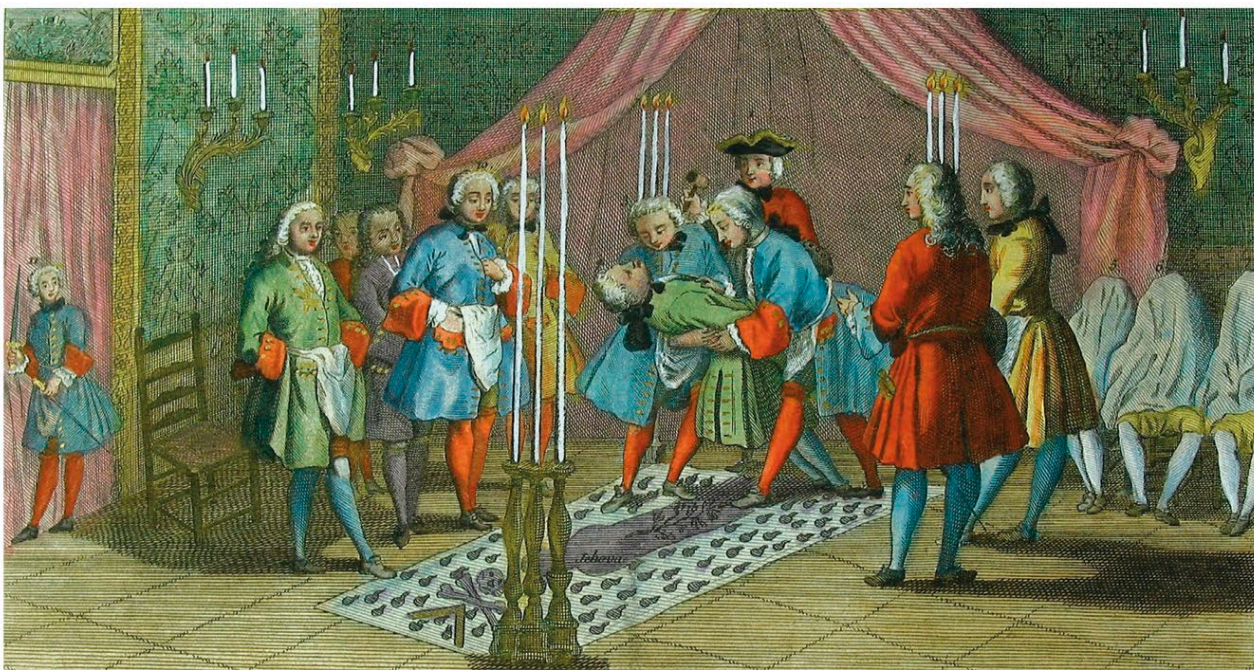
Self-styled Masonic champion



The Sicilian-born self-styled Count Alessandro di Cagliostro was a shameless charlatan of the 18th century—or an unfairly denounced visionary. Magician, alchemist, seer, and self-publicist, he is credited with establishing, in Italy, the Rite of High Egyptian Freemasonry, indebted to Hermeticism. His goal was the “perfection of mankind,” a state attained through the study of Middle Eastern teaching, alchemy, and Freemasonry: the whole a “journey to enlightenment.” However, he made many enemies and died, in Rome, a victim of the Inquisition.

Freemasons, and they enthusiastically adopted many of the earlier practices. Ceremonies included the three stages or degrees whereby medieval masons were inducted: Entered Apprentice; Fellowcraft; and Master Mason. Elaborate and mysterious rituals went with each stage. They likewise grouped themselves in “lodges,” named after the temporary on-site structures from which a Master Mason originally oversaw any project.

The establishment in London of the United Grand Lodge of England in 1717 cemented the modern movement. The ritual observances of the original Freemasons were at its heart, and the organization was steeped in symbolism based on what were believed to be ancient precedents.



◀ Initiation ceremony

In this mid-18th-century French image, the initiate, swooning because he has just been struck by a mallet, is laid down in a designated position. Covered figures, not allowed to watch the secret rite, sit to the right; sword aloft, a member guards the entrance at the left. The whole scene is lit by sets of triple candles.